discussion when the President (with the Defense Secretary) met the Joint Chiefs on Friday, 19 October. Washington's attitude to mobilisation and preparedness was not shared by Harold Macmillan. On 22 October he told General Norstad that mobilisation sometimes caused war, and on 27 October informed the Chief of the Air Staff, Sir Thomas Pike, that he did not want overt preparations.

The possibility that the Soviets might misunderstand a US alert was hardly unfamiliar territory to senior officials. On 23 August 1962 the Net Evaluation Subcommittee (NES) – a subcommittee of the NSC – briefed senior figures after the President requested examination of a nuclear exchange between the US and the USSR.[52] The attendees included Dean Rusk, Robert McNamara, Roswell Gilpatric, John McCone, Robert Kennedy, Maxwell Taylor, and McGeorge Bundy. The NES devised a scenario involving a war in South-East Asia begun by a Sino-Soviet-backed invasion of South Vietnam by North Vietnam that escalates into a strategic nuclear exchange. Thermonuclear war breaks out when the Soviets mistakenly believe that a heightened US alert posture is preparation for an imminent US nuclear attack on the USSR and decide to get their retaliation in first.

The US declaration of DEFCON-3 on 22 October 1962, the increase in airborne alerted B-52s, and SAC's unprecedented move to DEFCON-2 on 24 October, significantly enhanced the readiness of the United States to wage nuclear war – although as noted, even at the normal peacetime alert level of DEFCON-5, Moscow was still faced with a force of nuclear weapons ready to lay waste to the USSR within a matter of hours.

We do not know how the GRU or the Soviet General Staff interpreted the changes in US readiness. In the literature, DEFCON-2 is invariably and mistakenly described as one level below war – DEFCON-1 was, in fact, a maximum readiness posture to be declared when war was considered imminent.[53] According to Sergei Khrushchev, his father believed the DEFCON-2 alert was a bluff, but still took it into account.[54] According to Deputy Foreign Minister Vasily Kuznetsov, when Nikita Khrushchev learned of the DEFCON-2 alert, he 'shat his pants'.[55]